Almost Normal

by Jason Sheets

NARRATOR: When I was in the fourth grade, my friends and I? We knew how to mess around! We would kick little first graders off the teeter-totters or take Becky Phipher's four-square ball. But our favorite game of all was to imitate the kids from Mrs. Johnson's special ed. class. "Act Like a Retard!" we'd call it. Really clever title. But I was good at this game. I was the master. I had the hand gestures down and everything. I could make fun of those retards better than anyone. Jimmy Stinson always said I was the best actor he'd ever met. I said no. I'd just learned it from my brother.

INTRODUCTION

Wow. That was really hard to say, and even harder to do. Why? Because it felt wrong. It felt hateful. No one ever uses diabetes or cancer to denigrate another person. You see, having a medical condition does not make someone lesser or sub-human, and having a cognitive condition shouldn't be any different.

But it wasn't always so . . . The R-word was once a slang term that could be heard everywhere: on playgrounds, in hallways and locker rooms; in televisions shows, movies and all-over social media.

In fact, it wasn't until 2010 that our federal government removed the term "mental retardation" from all federal statutes and replaced it with the term "intellectual disability."

You see, words have power. They can crush a heart or heal it. They can shame a soul or liberate it. They can shatter dreams or energize them.

*In this selection, our narrator comes to the realization that his brother Todd is **NOT** a 'retard' . . . He's Almost Normal by Jason Sheets.*

NARRATOR: My brother, Todd, is nine years older than me. I wasn't even born yet when Todd was diagnosed with mild to moderate mental retardation. Which basically means that somehow, some way, he managed to score a 40 on an IQ test he couldn't even read.

It was kind of difficult figuring out who the baby of the family was: me, because of my age, or Todd, because of his mentality. Either way, Todd caused our entire family to be the

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object of pity from people in town. I remember one teacher, Mrs. Simpkins, who would always say:

MRS. SIMPKINS: It must be rough having a simple-minded brother. Does it bother you much?

NARRATOR: No. Not until people start talking about it. That was the truth. It didn't bother me much. It just meant that there were certain rules around the house:

RULE #1: Don't say anything you don't want repeated. Like once I said, "U2 sucks." Just a general comment. So then he's walking around the house saying, “You hear that? It SUCKS! U2 sucks!” A half-hour later he asks: "What's U2?"

RULE #2: Don't let Todd request songs at church. Last time he did, he wanted everyone to "do the Vogue!"

RULE #3: Never play Uno with Todd. He'll play a red card and say "WILD! Change it to red!"

RULE #4: Never, ever, expect anyone to have any time for you because YOU are normal. YOU don't need attention.

And Todd loved to talk. It didn't matter if anyone else was in the room, he'd keep up both ends of the conversation. Once I saw him just staring at the wall, talking to himself. I said, "This guy is crazy. He really needs professional help!" Then I thought: who am I talking to?

His favorite topic of conversation was whether he was “**retarded”** or not. I would just tell him that we are all retarded in certain ways. See, retarded means "slow," not "stupid."

But I put up with his ramblings. 24 hours a day; 365 days a year. I wasn't even safe on my birthday. I didn't even have parties anymore. I was getting ready to blow out the candles when Todd walked up and blew them out for me. And not to be selfish, but that was my birthday moment! My wish. . . and I could have used one!

What did my parents do? They hugged him. See, Todd had never blown out a candle before. They brought out the camera and took a picture of him with the cake.

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April 11, 1982: The night of my big solo at the spring concert. Mom missed it. She was out in the lobby giving Todd his 8:00 dose of Mellaril. He has to have it at exactly 8:00. So, she missed my solo. Dad saw it and said I was great. Mom took his word for it.

My brother is rather hard to describe. Let's see . . . he likes anything with cops or firemen, so his favorite TV show is "Rescue 911." His favorite movie is "Beverly Hills Cop." His favorite color is red -- fire-engine red.

Number of embarrassing moments he has caused: 447.
Number of shirts he owns: 25.
Number of shirts he wears: 6.
Number he can count to: 19.
Number of dishes he has broken: 38.
Number of times he's said "I love you": 2,714.
Number of times I've told him I love him: 4.

Trips to the mall were the worst. For some reason, Todd saw this as his chance to pick up chicks. I tried to explain to him that "Whew, shake it for my baby!" was not the coolest pick-up line.

One day, we were walking out of Walgreen's when a store clerk stopped us. She said Todd had taken something from their store without paying for it. I explained to her that he couldn't have because Todd does not steal. He may be slow, but he does not steal. She asked if she could search his pockets. I said "Fine, go ahead." Then she pulled out two packs of M&M's and a Twix bar from Todd's coat pocket. I couldn't believe it. I asked him why he did it. He said he was hungry.

I pleaded with the clerk not to call mom and dad, but she did anyway. When they heard, they decided it was time to place Todd in a group home. They said they couldn't control him anymore. But they could have. They just didn't want to.

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I'll never forget the look on his face when we dropped him off at that group home forever. I said, "I love you" and he said nothing. He stared at me with those big, blue eyes, tears streaming down his cheek, looking at me like I was some sort of Judas. That was two years ago. Todd still gets to come home on the holidays, and I still visit him every Saturday. Sometimes we talk. Sometimes not. He appears a year older every time I see him. It's the same Todd, but something is missing. Something real. Something good.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
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